CRISIS BRIEFING (EXTENDED): "The Friday Counterfeit"

To: Operational Task Force (all teams)
Classification: Urgent. Do not distribute outside this room.
Current time: Friday, 2:00 PM
Hard deadlines: 4:00 PM reporter's comment deadline · 4:45 PM staff lineup · 5:00 PM article publishes and doors open

You have already been taught how to write a BLUF, how to triage, and how to pitch. **Nobody will teach you today. Use it.**

1. The Situation

You are the **Operational Task Force** for **Bleu Hen Hospitality Group**, the most talked-about farm-to-table restaurant group in Delaware.

> *"Raised Close. Served Honest."*

Three locations: **Bleu Hen Bistro** (Wilmington Riverfront, the flagship), **The Bleu Hen Roost** (Main Street, Newark) and **Bleu Hen Brasserie** (Greenville). About 140 employees, many of whom live on tips. Your Owner started with one 40-seat bistro in 2015 and built it into a three-time winner of "Best Farm-to-Table in the First State." Every menu carries one promise in print:

> *"Every bird, every cut, every catch: raised, grown or caught within 75 miles of your table."*

That promise is why guests pay about 40% more here than anywhere comparable. It is not marketing on top of the business. **It is the business.**

Tonight is the biggest night of the year

It is **Friday, February 13th**, the start of Valentine's weekend. All three restaurants are completely booked, and your signature offering is **The Lovebird Tasting**, a five-course dinner for two at $185 a couple. The marquee dishes have names that appear on every menu card:

- **Fifty-Mile Flounder** with brown butter
- **Sussex Hen Roulade**
- **Brandywine Pork Duo**
- **Surf & Turf for Two**

Every dish credits one farm by name: **Brandywine Heritage Farms & Fisheries**, your exclusive supplier. The founder, Calvin Teague, is a local celebrity. He has a handshake with half the Chamber of Commerce. He has eaten at your bistro. Your Executive Chef calls him by his first name.

There are **1,130 reservations** this weekend. Some of them are first dates. Some are anniversaries. At least a few are marriage proposals; the Riverfront staff has been quietly arranging them for weeks. A table of 14 at the Bistro is booked for a retirement party. The Greenville dining room has a state official's table reserved for Saturday.

Then, at 1:41 PM, this happened

A local investigative food reporter, **Jo Alvarez** of *The Delmarva Dispatch*, posted a teaser on social media (see **Exhibit A**). She says the "local, sustainable" supplier behind a three-location restaurant group is repackaging cheap, factory-farmed product from out-of-state industrial processors and selling it as local. She says she has a paper trail. She says the story publishes at **5:00 PM today**.

She did not need to name you. There is exactly one restaurant client in the state with a three-location footprint and an exclusive Brandywine contract.

At 1:30 PM, Alvarez emailed your Marketing Director for comment and gave you until **4:00 PM** to respond on the record.

The teaser has been shared more than 1,200 times in 19 minutes. Your reservation system shows **14 cancellations since 1:41**. Two local TV newsrooms have called, and a third is on its way. Your phones at the Bistro are ringing and the host stand does not know what to say.

What is in your walk-in coolers right now

Every walk-in at all three locations is stocked with Brandywine product for tonight's service: chicken, pork, flounder, rockfish and some beef. **$40,000 of it, paid for and sitting there.** The sous chefs have already started tonight's prep. Flounder was portioned this morning. The roulade was rolled at noon.

What you know, and what makes you nervous

On Tuesday, the Riverfront sous chef, **Tess Aguilar**, peeled a shipping sticker off a delivery box and found a second label underneath, with an out-of-state plant code. She took a photo, but it's blurry. She sent it to Chef Rafi Moreno, who replied: *"Pallets get re-boxed all the time. Don't worry about it."* Today he hasn't said much at all.

Other things that look bad:
- Brandywine's invoices dropped **14% in November**. Teague called it "volume pricing."
- Chef Rafi has noticed the "heritage" pork has lacked its usual marbling for about three weeks.
- Alvarez's teaser says she has a "paper trail."

Other things that suggest it might not be true:
- You visited Brandywine's farm twice. The last visit, in September, looked genuine.
- The state agriculture department inspected their home farm last spring, and it passed.
- The teaser has no specifics. Perhaps only some products are affected.
- Teague has years of goodwill, and 60 people in Sussex County work for him.

What you don't know: Which products? Since when? What does Alvarez actually have? Whether Teague knew your Owner would be exposed.

You will not be able to find out by 5:00 PM. You must decide anyway.

Who's in the building

PERSON	ROLE	MOOD
The Owner	Founder. Your boss.	Time-starved, panicked, very proud of the brand. Waiting on you.
Chef Rafi Moreno	Executive Chef, all three kitchens	Fiery and loyal. Feels responsible. Defensive if blamed. Follows clear orders.
Tess Aguilar	Sous chef, Riverfront	Anxious. Wonders whether she should have pushed harder on Tuesday.
Priya Nair	Group General Manager	Calm. Worried about the staff and their tips.
Lena Cho	Marketing Director	Phone is blowing up. Wants to "get ahead of it."
Hal Brandt	Outside counsel	Careful. "Don't say anything you can't prove."

Your calendar for the rest of the day

TIME	WHAT HAPPENS
2:00 PM	**You convene.**
2:30 PM	**Status Brief #1.** The Owner wants a 90-second update from each team.
2:45 PM	Same-day cutoff for the conventional distributor's order
4:00 PM	**Reporter's deadline for an on-the-record comment**
4:05 PM	**Your deliverables lock.** The Owner meets each team.
4:45 PM	**Staff lineup** at all three locations (moved back from 4:15 so you have time). Servers hear whatever you've decided.
5:00 PM	**The article publishes. Doors open.**
5:30 PM	First seatings at the Bistro and the Roost
6:00 PM	Local TV crews expected outside

Warning: The clock does not stop for breaks. When the session breaks at about 3:10 PM, **25 minutes of story time will pass.** Plan for it.

2. The Stakes

Sunk inventory in the coolers	**$40,000**
Projected weekend revenue at risk	**$200,000** (1,130 covers, about $177 average check)
Valentine's deposits held	**$56,500** ($50 per guest). Refundable if the group cancels
Gift certificates already sold for this weekend	$18,000
Estimated weekend tips for staff	About $38,000
Annual supplier spend	About $1.1 million, under a **3-year exclusive contract with 18 months remaining**
Jobs	About 140 at Bleu Hen, plus about 60 at Brandywine
Time until the article drops	**3 hours**

Every path costs something. Throwing out the inventory and canceling reservations means certain, immediate losses. Serving the product means betting the brand on not getting caught. Pulling it could mean a fight with the supplier, a contract dispute, and hurting people who may be innocent. **Doing nothing is also a decision.**

3. How Today Works

You will not get a clean, complete briefing. You will get a pile of facts, some of them contradictory, **and you will be interrupted all day.** That is the exercise.

Real time

The story clock tracks the session clock almost one for one. When the wall clock says 3:05 PM, it is 3:05 PM in the story.

The Resource Desk

Behind the Resource Desk are the people you can call: your Chef, your sous chef, your GM, your Marketing Director, your lawyer, your suppliers, your insurance broker, your supplier's CEO and the reporter herself. See **Exhibit N** for the directory and the call rules.

- Your team has a limited number of **call tokens** (see Rules).
- Send one caller with a Call Slip. Calls last **3 minutes at most.**
- Whatever you say on a call, **you said.** If you tell Chef Rafi to stop rolling product, he stops. If you tell Lena to change the website, she does.
- People will also call **you**, without warning. Inbound calls and visitors do not cost tokens, and they will want an answer now.

The Dossier

Exhibits A through N are your evidence. Some matter. Some are noise. Some conflict. Reading them carefully is part of the job.

The Owner

The Owner will come back more than once, in a different mood each time, with new demands, new fears and new ideas. **Some of the Owner's ideas are bad.** You are expected to say so.

The Field Check

Sous chef Tess can inspect the Tuesday delivery at the Riverfront Bistro. It takes her 8 minutes and costs 2 tokens. It will tell you something. It will not tell you everything.

4. Your Five Outputs

Status Brief #1 (90 seconds, at 2:30 PM, spoken)

A BLUF to the Owner: what you know, what you plan, what you need. No slides, no script.

Deliverable 1: BLUF Memo to the Owner (exactly 3 sentences)

Your overall strategy. Recommendation first. Include the cost and the ask.

Deliverable 2: 3-Point Operational Pivot for the Executive Chef (exactly 3 points)

Directives, not suggestions. Cover the **current food**, **tonight's service** and **what the Chef must do before service**.

Deliverable 3: Front-of-House Guest Script (exactly 2 sentences)

What servers say to guests at 5:00 PM. It is taught at the 4:45 PM lineup. It must sound human to a nervous couple celebrating Valentine's Day.

Deliverable 4: On-the-Record Statement to Jo Alvarez (at most 4 sentences, due 4:00 PM)

Jo has asked three questions (you'll receive them in the afternoon). **Your statement will be printed.** Whatever you write will appear in the article, word for word. Lies and evasions are published too.

5. Rules of Engagement

- **Teams:** Two teams. Both receive the same facts. You are competing, and you can't see each other's calls.
- **Call tokens: 12 per team** of 10 (8 per team of 5). Each call costs 1 token. The field check costs 2.
- **Call slips:** Write the name of the person and the question. One caller at a time per team. Everyone else keeps working.
- **No copying.** You may not eavesdrop on the other team's calls or cards.
- **Orders are binding.** What you tell staff to do is done.
- **Spokespeople:** Elect **1 or 2**. Everyone contributes, but the Owner may question **any** team member.
- **Everyone may be interrupted at any time**, including mid-sentence, mid-call, and mid-pitch.
- **Deliverables lock at 4:05 PM.** One copy of each, on the worksheet. No edits.
- **Pitch format:** 4 minutes to pitch, then questioning by the Owner. Expect to be cut off.
- **Don't read to the Owner.**

6. Suggested Way to Work (optional)

A team of 10 working a 3-hour crisis needs structure. This split is a suggestion.

ROLE	JOB
Commander (1)	Keeps the plan, assigns work, makes the final call when the team splits
Intel (2)	Reads the dossier, finds conflicts, runs the field check
Calls (2)	Work the Resource Desk. One makes calls; one logs
Finance (1)	Owns the money: inventory, replacement costs, deposits, contract exposure
Kitchen (1)	Owns Deliverable 2 and every conversation with the Chef
Guest and Staff (1)	Owns Deliverable 3 and every conversation with Priya, Lena and the staff
Comms (1)	Owns Deliverable 4, the press, and the wording of everything public
Spokesperson (1 to 2)	Pitches. Sits with every group so the story stays consistent

Roles can double up. Reassign as the situation changes. **Never let one person hold all the information.**

7. Pitch Structure

1. **Current state:** where things stand.
2. **Proposed action (BLUF first):** what you recommend.
3. **Immediate cost:** in dollars and consequences.
4. **The ask:** what you need from the Owner right now.

8. Questions to Consider

These are prompts, not hints.

- What do you know, what do you assume, and what are you hoping is true?
- Which of your options can you undo, and which cannot be undone?
- What is the contract actually allowing? Has anyone read it?
- Whom do you have to tell first? Whom do you have to protect?
- What will you be proud of, or ashamed of, when this is read aloud at 5:00?

Dossier

EXHIBIT	WHAT IT IS
A	The reporter's teaser post (1:41 PM)
B	Reservation board and cancellation log (2:00 PM)
C	Text thread: Tess and Chef Rafi
D	The Lovebird Tasting menu and "Meet Your Farmer"
E	The reporter's email to Marketing
G	Brandywine Master Supply Agreement (excerpts)
H	Brandywine invoice history, September to January
I	Walk-in inventory, all three locations
J	Replacement supply options
K	Insurance policy excerpt
L	Staffing, tips and deposits
M	Newspaper profile of the Owner (2024)
N	Who you can reach, with call rules and a call log